coalition guaranteed its military superiority over imperialism in the 1970s'.24 A few weeks later, on 24 October, he led an 'inspiring meeting of fraternal friendship' to Bratislava, where alongside Willi Stoph, he addressed the Slovakian National Council.

Amid all this activity, rumours abetted by malicious tittle-tattle about turmoil in Honecker's private life would not go away. In 2016, a former GDR lawyer, Götz Berger, claimed Erich and Margot's marriage was secretly dissolved in the spring of 1970.25 Although never proven, Berger alleged matters were so serious that the couple sought legal opinion and, equally revealing was an anecdote about Politburo member Alfred Neumann reputedly letting it slip that he had a 'complicated appointment' ahead of him: 'I have to speak to Margot,' he told a friend. 'She wants a divorce! You can't do that in her position.' (He also made the same comment to other confidants.) By this point, it was widely rumoured Margot was embroiled in a relationship with a young actor, four years her junior, engaged at the Deutsches Theater, a canard that later took on the authority of fact among some German tabloid newspapers.26 Versions of the story percolated around the SED for the next nineteen years. Contrary to Brezhnev's order, there can be little doubt that Ulbricht continued his incessant backbiting and spread unsavoury details about Honecker's private life.

By this time, the First Secretary's mind was quickly distracted by a sudden shortage of consumer goods and foodstuffs which aroused discontent, sparking strikes and unrest. Sniffing an opportunity, Honecker aggravated the problem by engineering an ill-tempered Central Committee meeting in December 1970. He encouraged Hanna Wolf, the rector of the Karl Marx SED party college, to lead the charge by angrily denouncing that gaps in supply – especially in the medical field – had left pharmacies without cough syrup and other medicines. During the discussion, Ulbricht was blamed for the difficulties which left hundreds of companies unable to fulfil goals, despite working overtime. 'Honecker had been working purposefully behind the scenes for some time to establish his power,' Günter Schabowski recounted. 'He had a concept and had people behind it who were just as devoted to it as the Ulbricht team was to their boss.'27